

OPINION

Declining Literacy Rates in ASEAN: The Imperative of Alleviating the Problem

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Photo: UNICEF

Timor-Leste boasts 2 official languages (Portuguese and Tetun Dili), 2 working languages (English and Bahasa Indonesia), and over 30 other indigenous languages.¹ Whilst the majority of the individuals living in or around our capital city, Dili, are largely proficient in the two official languages, those living in the rural areas of the country are unlikely to have anything beyond a rudimentary understanding of the languages.

This becomes an extreme impediment when children from rural areas start attending school, where Portuguese and Tetun Dili are the two instructional languages. The question is: How impactful is an academic education when students enter school lacking proficiency in the language of instruction?

¹ International and Area Studies Library, “LibGuides: Timor-Leste (East Timor): Languages,” [guides.library.illinois.edu](https://guides.library.illinois.edu/timor-leste/language), October 11, 2024, <https://guides.library.illinois.edu/timor-leste/language>.

As of 2022, the literacy rates of youths, categorised as people of age 15 to 24 years old, in Timor-Leste lie at 69%, 24% below the average literacy rate across the globe.² The language barrier, coupled with other problems such as the underfunding of schools, reduced enrolment, and decreasing comprehension rates amongst children in their early developmental stages lead to an increase in student drop out rates, with students finding the school curriculum too difficult.

The decline of literacy rates within the new generation elicits several disadvantages that will ultimately hinder them even as they step into adulthood. The importance of literacy can be seen through research that shows a 21.25% increase in wages and a 8.1% increase in the probability of being employed for individuals who are literate.³ Illiterate individuals often face unemployment or low wages when entering the workforce, thereby exacerbating the cycle of poverty in the nation.⁴

The Minister of Timor Leste emphasised the significance of addressing current literacy levels, stating that “Improving literacy rates amongst the younger generation is vital because they are the future of our country. Education is the driving force in maintaining the economic state of smaller nations like Timor-Leste.”

Proposed Solutions and Frameworks

As such, the Minister of Timor-Leste has proposed the National Additive Multilanguage Education, or NAME for short. This programme is aimed at enhancing language policy in its entirety through 2 distinct phases.

Phase 1: Phase 1 will begin early stages of basic education by substituting various indigenous mother tongues as the instructional language. For instance, the children living in the Liquiçá

² “Literacy Rate, Adult Total (% of People Ages 15 and Above) - Timor-Leste | Data,” data.worldbank.org, n.d., <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SE.ADT.LITR.ZS?locations=TL>.

³ Maúna Soares de Baldini Rocha and Vladimir Ponczek, “The Effects of Adult Literacy on Earnings and Employment,” *Economics of Education Review* 30, no. 4 (August 2011): 755–64, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.econedurev.2011.03.005>.

⁴ “The Connection between Illiteracy and Poverty,” www.illiteracyinitiative.info, November 8, 2023, <https://www.illiteracyinitiative.info/the-connection-between-illiteracy-and-poverty>.

Municipality of Timor-Leste, who primarily speak the dialect of Tukudede,⁵ would start their elementary education learning in Tukudede.

This allows children to comprehend foundational concepts and understandings by building off on what they already know, narrowing the learning gap between spoken and written language. This then prevents cognitive shock that may lead to future burnout.

Phase 2: In the implementation of phase 2, schools will gradually transition into using Portuguese and Tetun Dilli as the main instructional languages. Extra contrastive analysis lessons will teach students how to translate their respective dialects into the official languages. This promises a smooth integration into the new instructional languages, avoiding mass confusion due to the sudden language switch.

The NAME programme ensures that in addition to fluency in English and Bahasa Indonesia, which are taught as classes in school, students have a comprehensive grasp on the two official languages of Timor-Leste. Equipping students with this multilingual framework will ultimately provide them with substantial advantages in the future.

Students partaking in NAME will benefit from the perquisites of multilingualism far beyond their schooling years. The linguistic diversity of these participants opens doors to employment opportunities, such as overseas positions, that would not be typically accessible to monolingual candidates. This would ultimately result in a significant improvement in the standards of living, giving disadvantaged children a second chance at a more fulfilling life.

However, the NAME programme does not merely benefit the people of Timor-Leste. Countries all across the ASEAN region face the same problem, but lack sufficient resources to take measurable action. Studies carried out by UNICEF showed that 1 in 2 children in Southeast Asia do not meet the expected literacy standard at Grade 5.⁶ This highlights the

⁵ Joshua Project, "Tokode in Timor-Leste," Joshuaproject.net, 2016, https://joshuaproject.net/people_groups/15536/TT.

⁶ "1 in 2 Children in Southeast Asia Still Lagging behind in Reading; Math Shows Slight Improvement," Unicef.org, 2025, <https://www.unicef.org/eap/press-releases/1-2-children-southeast-asia-still-lagging-behind-reading-math-shows-slight>.

urgency for stronger investment in basic literacy to ensure the disadvantaged children of ASEAN are not left behind.

In essence, NAME is not simply a framework of empty promises; it is a crucial step that should be taken in order to combat the failing literacy levels in the region. Thus, the Minister of Timor-Leste urges the ministers of the ASEAN Education Ministers Meeting (ASEM) to coordinate their resources and supplies to achieve the most promising outcomes possible.

The Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (EMBLI) Pilot Program

The Minister of Timor-Leste is confident that NAME will be effective in addressing and alleviating the decreasing literacy levels following a similar programme that had garnered success. He noted that if incorporated on a larger scale with the support of fellow ASEAN members, NAME can flourish as well as its predecessor.

Prior to NAME, Timor-Leste launched the Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education Pilot Programme, or EMBLI for short, aimed at improving the current education system to increase literacy rates. The pilot project set out to test the feasibility of incorporating indigenous mother tongues as instructional languages in the early years of child development in order to develop early literacy.⁷

Further on in their schooling journey, students are then taught new second and third languages, where they will apply their knowledge of letter, vocabulary, and cognitive concepts from their first language to their further language learning.

The efficacy of EMBLI was measured by a test that assessed factors that include, but are not limited to, reading comprehension, mathematics, and word recognition. It is noteworthy that preschools involved in the EMBLI programme showed significant improvement and gain of up to 300 times.⁸

⁷ Stephen Walter, “The Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (EMBLI) Pilot Program Endline Assessment Executive Summary Timor-Leste,” 2016, <https://laohamutuk.org/educ/CAFE/EvalEMBLIExecSummEn.pdf>.

⁸ Stephen Walter, “The Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (EMBLI) Pilot Program Endline Assessment Executive Summary Timor-Leste,” 2016, <https://laohamutuk.org/educ/CAFE/EvalEMBLIExecSummEn.pdf>.

Seeing as EMBLI facilitated the further development of oral and literate competency in the co-official languages of Timor-Leste,⁹ the government of Timor-Leste strongly believes that NAME will produce the same, if not better, results.

To improve the standards of living of children all across the ASEAN region, it is imperative to agree on a solution that will be mutually beneficial to all member states, such as NAME. By taking action to improve early education and literacy rates, it is undeniable that the ASED will be able to rectify the imbalance befittingly.

***This is an opinion article prepared for educational purposes only, and strictly reflects the author's personal opinion and does not bind any institution with which the author may be affiliated.**

⁹ Stephen Walter, "The Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (EMBLI) Pilot Program Endline Assessment Executive Summary Timor-Leste," 2016, <https://laohamutuk.org/educ/CAFE/EvalEMBLIExecSummEn.pdf>.

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